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AFP

NOBEL PEACE PRIZE WINNER COMES OUT OF HIDING

■ Nobel peace laureate Maria Corina Machado waves to supporters as she walks towards the Parliament for a visit in Oslo yesterday. Machado arrived in Norway's capital hours after the Venezuelan opposition leader's award was collected on her behalf by her daughter. Machado said yesterday that she doesn't believe the Venezuelan government knew where she was hiding for 11 months.

Double payout for IndiGo flyers

Budget carrier to offer vouchers and refunds worth up to Rs20,000

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

A beleaguered IndiGo announced yesterday it will compensate passengers affected by a series of flight cancellations and delays earlier this month, offering vouchers worth up to Rs10,000 (approx Dh410) to those "severely impacted" by the travel disruption. The airline confirmed that the vouchers can be used for

any IndiGo journey over the next 12 months and are being issued in addition to government-mandated refunds and compensation guidelines.

More compensation

Moreover, under the Indian government guidelines, IndiGo is also required to pay affected passengers between Rs5,000 and Rs10,000 depending on the block time of their cancelled flights. That means some travellers could receive double compensation — both the government payout and the airline's Rs10,000 goodwill voucher. "We will offer travel vouch-

ers worth Rs10,000 to such severely impacted customers," an IndiGo spokesperson said, adding that the airline remained "committed to restoring the experience passengers expect from us — safe, smooth and reliable."

IndiGo stated that refunds for cancelled flights have already been initiated, with most passengers seeing amounts reflected in their accounts. Those who booked via travel portals have also had refund actions initiated, the airline said. The disruption took place between December 3 and 5. **SEE ALSO P-III**

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UAE tightens drug laws with fines, jail, deportation

5 YEARS IMPRISONMENT AND FINE OF NOT LESS THAN DH50,000 FOR MISUSE

DUBAI
BY ANUPAM VARMA
News and Business Editor

The UAE has tightened laws to combat use of narcotics, including imprisonment and heavy penalties for medical practitioners who misuse their authority to prescribe and dispense such drugs. It also mandates the deportation of foreign nationals convicted of narcotics offences following the completion of their sentences. Under the amendments to certain provisions of the Federal Decree-Law on Combating Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances, references to the Ministry of Health and Prevention and the Minister of Health and Prevention in the original law are replaced with the Emirates Drug Establishment and its chairperson, establishing the entity as the competent authority responsible for the regulation of medical products in the country.

Central role

References to the Ministry of Interior are replaced with the National Anti-Narcotics Authority, reflecting its central role in leading national efforts to combat narcotics-related crimes. The amendments also enhance the capacity of the health sector by permitting federal health authorities and private health facilities to establish specialised units for the treatment

EXCEPTIONS

The court must order the deportation of a convicted foreigner, except in two specific cases: where the person is the spouse or first-degree relative of a UAE citizen at the time of committing the offence, or where the person is a member of a family residing in the UAE and the court determines that deportation would cause serious harm to the stability of the family or deprive a family member of necessary care, provided the family has the financial ability to support treatment.

and rehabilitation of individuals addicted to narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances. The decree-law introduces stricter penalties for dispensing narcotic drugs or psychotropic substances without a valid prescription or in quantities exceeding approved limits. The penalty for such a violation is imprisonment for not less than five years and a fine of not less than Dh50,000. The amendments also increase penalties for any physician who issues a prescription for a narcotic drug or psychotropic substance without a licence, without medical justification, or in violation of approved limits. The penalty is imprisonment for not less than five years and a fine of not less than Dh50,000.

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